from the beginning,' Honecker noted on 19 September. 'You can't take his praise for Gorbachev seriously,' he cattily remarked, referring to the gushing words drooling from Gromyko's pen.8 Honecker's own attempt at a written chronicle – scrawled into a school notebook – included a painful amount of brooding but little self-analysis. 'The tragedy of the GDR,' he mused, was 'particularly great because it was – besides the USSR – the most developed socialist country, one real alternative to the imperialist system.'9 The German Democratic Republic, he contended, was an indispensable part of history. 'No amount of anti-socialist agitation can make history disappear.'10 He lamented that former citizens would miss 'what was particularly dear to them about the GDR', including affordable housing, social security, vacations for everyone, and university opportunities for the working classes.

In general, Becker told the author, Honecker adapted well to prison life. 'He chose to wear the regulation clothing and never complained. He showed a certain dignity and got on well with the other inmates.' He never showed any regret about the loss of his status and of his privileges, in contrast to 'many fallen businessmen doing time in Moabit who showed the whiny side of their personality. On his birthday, he asked for 'Mon Cheri', a popular chocolate praline with cherry and a small amount of liquor. This wish was denied by the presiding judge because alcohol was forbidden in prison'.11

A new CT scan in August 1992 confirmed the existence of a malignant tumour in the right lobe of his liver, prompting defence lawyers to fruitlessly request legal proceedings – as far as they were aimed against their client – be abandoned and the arrest warrant withdrawn.

In fact, until the very eve of the trial's opening, concerns about the health of the defendants eclipsed the actual case. For a few days, Honecker's focus shifted to Margot, after an organisation known as 'Help' (an association for the victims of political violence in Europe) brought a second charge against her in connection with compulsory adoptions. The application was filed on behalf of Carola Jacob, who was given an eighteen-month prison term in 1979 because of 'an attempt to cross the GDR border illegally', and 'antisocial behaviour'. During her incarceration, Jacob was informed that her 7-year-old son, Michael, had been adopted by order. The first charge